

change what you don't like. The OS also ties into the Apps eco system. If you are one who has an Android smartphone, then an Android tablet will do you good. If you are a Mac or iPhone user, then syncing your iPad with them will be easy.

Specifications

Single-core, dual-core or quad-core, doesn't really matter much unless you're running CPU intensive apps. What does matter, however, is the amount of RAM available. Ensure that you choose a tablet with at least 1GB of RAM to ensure a smooth experience.

Connectivity

If you don't plan on buying a SIM to depend on India's iffy 3G implementation, or don't want to pay the extra data costs, *and* if everywhere you go you get Wi-Fi access, don't pay extra for a 3G slot, the Wi-Fi only model will do.

However, if you just absolutely need to be online everywhere you go, you have no choice really. Some tablets such as the Samsung Galaxy Tab 2 also double up as a phone, and although not recommended, you could theoretically choose to use it as your primary cell phone as well.

Input and output

Devices such as the iPad and the Samsung Galaxy Note 800 come with their own proprietary dock connector. So if you want to use accessories, you will have to stick to a closed ecosystem. Some other tablets such as the Funbook Pro, Mercury MTab Neo 2, etc.

support micro USB inputs and offer a native HDMI-out reducing the restriction to accessories and connectivity options.

Battery life

Go to www.thinkdigit.com and look at the tested battery life for the tablets you're considering. As for specs, make sure the battery is at least 4,000mAh for a 7-inch device.

Things that don't matter

Rear camera

If you're going to use a smartphone in conjunction with your tablet, just keep using that to shoot your pictures.

Preloaded apps

Chances are you're going to delete them all anyway. If they're good paid apps, you can maybe consider them, otherwise ignore.

Stylus

This is outdated. If you wanted to use a stylus instead of your fingers, you'd still be using PDAs.

Speaker

A tablet is a personal device and if you are consuming multimedia content on the go, you will undoubtedly be using headphones.

Recommendations

Well, if you want the best in the market pick up the third generation iPad (64GB 4G+Wi-Fi at ₹50,900). It has very impressive specifications under the hood, has a fantastic display and battery life and an app ecosystem to keep you occupied for months on end. Simply put, it's the best tablet money can buy. If you are looking for something cheaper, the Nexus 7 (coming soon) or the Samsung Galaxy Tab 2 are the devices for you.

Both have 7-inch displays, great specifications under the hood and the Tab 2 also doubles up as a phone. If it's a budget tablet you want, a smart buy would be the Zync Z999 Plus. It has an average display and only 512MB of RAM, but still has the ability to run almost all the apps from the Play store. It also plays back 1080p video smoothly and has a SIM card slot.



Buying a smartphone isn't the simplest decision you will ever make. You need to be smart, considering the range, variety and the plethora of specs on offer.

7 things that should matter

Not everything that comes within the package should impact your buying decision. And this is particularly true when choosing between two phones that are very similar on the spec sheet as well as the price tag.

Display size and type

This is what defines how small/big or portable the phone will be, and also the comfort of using the on-screen keypad is pretty dependent on screen real estate. If you text or IM a lot, you will need at least a 4-inch display.

As far as the display type is concerned, you don't want to spend above ₹30,000 and still be stuck with a plain LCD/LED display, while the rivals are toting the S-LCD2's and the AMOLED family of displays. If you use your phone to watch movies, the colour depth and crispness should be of utmost priority.

Keypad

On-screen keypads are a bit like snowflakes – no phone manufacturers seem to have the same on-screen keypad on their devices. Hence, identifying the most comfortable one for you is all about checking out the devices in person. What also matters is how well the keyboard UI is designed.

Battery

With the processors becoming more and more powerful and adding on more and more cores, and the ever increasing display sizes, battery life does take a pounding. Which is why, batteries rated at 1750mAh, 1900mAh and even 2100mAh are becoming standard with smartphones. You will also need to figure out what you'll do with your phone, and

DECISION TIME TABLETS

Windows 8 powered tablets are just around the corner and so far the word is that they are pretty impressive. If you are one who wants to weigh your options before you pick one up then wait for the Windows 8 devices to launch before making your final buying decision. If your last tablet purchase was up to 8 months ago, then you don't need to upgrade for the next 6 months at least. If however, you are one who has the first generation iPad, Samsung Galaxy Tab or the first gen budget tablets, then it's time for you to pick up a new tablet.